in this lifetime would get reincarnated in India in the next. The concept of Western Heavens, the land of Lord Buddha's birth, ran deep in Chinese society, as did the fame of the Journey to the West on Xuan Zang's travels. At the same time, a narrative had also developed that India's social system was inherently flawed and lacking in societal cohesion. Nationalist sentiment in China saw India as compromising with Western liberalism, oblivious to its own emulation of competing ideologies.

Yet, anti-colonial feelings did lead to strong and persistent advocacy of Indian independence by China's leadership of that period. It went to the extent of vitiating their relationship with the British, especially with Winston Churchill. The role played by India as a rear base during the Second World War and the supply lifeline over the Himalayas enhanced this sense of affinity. Although this aspect receded in its prominence after 1949, new variants of the fraternity of the oppressed carried it forward. The saga of Dr Kotnis, an Indian leftist who died leading a medical mission during the Second World War, gained currency in both societies. Even the visit of India's national poet, Rabindranath Tagore, acquired positive political symbolism because of his opposition to Japanese militarism. Contemporary records may actually indicate a more mixed reception, but then history has usually been embellished by politics.

The afterglow of independence that created the basis for a Third World and lit up the Bandung Conference was the zenith of this phase. This narrative maintained its legs for a whole decade because it was politically advantageous for both nations to project a brotherhood. Its message of anti-imperialism fitted in with the Afro-Asian solidarity that the 1955 conference promoted to strengthen their standing with regard to the West. So too did a bilateral discourse that encouraged Indians to see Maoist China in more liberal terms than reality warranted. A sense of being on the same side of history contributed to working closely in international forums and of India standing up for China against the West. Its persistent advocacy of PRC representation at the UN was noteworthy, ironical given China's subsequent lack of reciprocal support for India's permanent membership of the Security Council. India was of use to China on both the Korean and Vietnam wars and the warning to the Americans of China preparing to enter the Korean War was conveyed through the Indian Ambassador in